

Hazrat Nooh

The First Messenger

After Nabi Adam , comes the story of Nabi Nooh , who is the first *Nabi* (Prophet) who has been honoured with being a Messenger (*Rasul*) of Allah. In Sahih Muslim under the chapter on Intercession there is a *Hadith* in which is said:

"O Nooh , you were the first on earth to be made a *Rasul*."

Call and Disobedience

By the time of the advent of Nabi Nooh , the whole nation had become far removed from the worship of the One Allah and from the light of true religion. Various false idols had been introduced to take place of the true God, and man had begun to worship those idols. Thus in accordance with the general practice by Allah, He sent one from among themselves to be a guide and spiritual leader for them. Nabi Nooh  was chosen and he proceeded to call them to the path of righteousness and invited them towards the true religion. However they refused to listen to his call and with stubborn resistance contempt rejected him. Both the leaders of the nation and the nobles rejected him and left no stone

untuned to leap scorn on him. The followers among the people followed their leaders and they too went out of their way to humiliate him. They were surprised that one who had no superiority over them as for as worldly means were concerned and who had no other special Angelic qualities should now claim to be a spiritual guide to them that we should follow his lead.

When these nobles saw some of the weak and poor people following Nabi Nooh عليه السلام, they said in an arrogant manner. "Do you want us to follow your leadership just like these ordinary people?" They considered those followers of Nooh عليه السلام to be mere blind followers, without any opinion of their own, unlike themselves who were the men of opinion among the people. They looked upon these followers as being incapable of understanding the reality of any situation. They reckoned that even if they were to listen to the words of Hazrat Nooh عليه السلام, They would first demand that he should put those lowly and poor folk away from him. Only after Nooh عليه السلام had put them away will they be prepared to listen to him as they were disgusted at those people and were unable to sit with them in one place.

Nabi Nooh عليه السلام heard their demand and gave just one answer: "What you demand will not come to pass because these people are Allah's sincere and righteous servants." If I should decide to do as you wish, then I will not be able of saving myself from Allah's punishment. I fear His punishment. With Allah sincerity counts a lot. With Him there is no question as to who is rich and who is poor. He further said to them:

"I have come to you, bringing Allah's message of guidance. I lay no claim to having knowledge of the unseen and neither do I claim to be an angel. I am Allah's chosen messenger and

apostle and my aim in life is to invite towards Allah. I have no claim to being richly endowed with worldly things; neither to being an Angel or a knower of the unseen."

These followers of mine, have with sincerity of heart accepted faith in Allah, and are looked upon by you as being despicable, lowly folk just because they are not rich like yourselves. Therefore in your opinion they are unable to attain to good or to true happiness because goodness and happiness in your opinion is only connected with worldly riches and wealth.

He also told them:

"In my mission of inviting towards Allah and in conveying His message to you, I do not need your wealth or any position of high rank, and neither do I desire any payment from you. My true payment is with Allah and He is the Best to appreciate my task."

Hazrat Nooh عليه السلام tried his utmost that his unfortunate people should understand and heed his call and attain the Mercy of Allah, but they refused to heed. And the more efforts were made in conveying Allah's commands to them, the more became their hatred and enmity and the more they tried to cause him harm and difficulty in all possible manner. The elders among them ordered the younger ones not to discard the worship of the false gods *Suwaa*, *Yaghooth*, *Ya'ooq* and *Nasr*. Finally, becoming highly annoyed with Nabi Nooh عليه السلام, they said:

"O Nooh عليه السلام, you have argued with us very much, and you should stop it now. Being now that punishment which you have promised us."

To this Nabi Nooh عليه السلام replied:

"If Allah so wishes, He will bring forth that punishment and you will not be able to frustrate Him."
(11.33)

In this manner when Nabi Nooh عليه السلام had completely despaired of them being recipients of *Hidaayat* and when their enmity and obstinacy had become very clear, and after having conveyed the Message of truth to them for nine-hundred and fifty years without any visible salutary effects, Nabi Nooh عليه السلام became greatly distressed. At that time by way of consolation, Allah said to him:

"Take those (of them) that have believed as no one else among them will now believe and do not sorrowful over their actions." Then it became clear to Nooh عليه السلام that he had not failed in his duty of delivering the message and that fault actually lay with those who refused to believe. This was all as a result of their rebellious nature. Then being affected by their actions, he lifted up his hands to Allah and prayed: "O Lord do not leave of the unbelievers a single one on earth. For if thou dost leave any of them, they will mislead thy devotees and they will breed none but wicked ungrateful ones."
(11.27)

Building the Ark

Allah accepted Nooh (*Alaihis Salām*)'s prayer and in accordance with His law of deeds and rewards and announced the punishment for the rebellious ones and the stubborn rejecters of truth and by way of saving the obedient ones

ordered Nabi Nooh عليه السلام to build a ship in order to save the lives of the believers from the coming punishment.

When Nabi Nooh عليه السلام started building the ship, the non-believers used to jeer and scoff at him. Whenever they used to pass by where he was building the ship they used to say: "very well, when we shall start drowning, you and your followers will be able to be saved with this ship.

What a stupid idea!"

Nabi Nooh عليه السلام, noticing their unmindfulness of the results of their actions and their courage in the face of their disobedience towards Allah, used to answer them in similar vein while keeping busy with his task of shipbuilding. As he knew what Allah had revealed to him of what is to take place:

"O Nooh, you are in our protection. And in accordance with our revelation, build the ship and do not ask us about them they will all drown."

(11:37)

At last the ship was built and the time for the coming of the punishment of Allah was near. Nabi Nooh عليه السلام saw the first signs of it as water started gushing forth from the earth like fountains. Then came the revelation:

To let those of his family members take their places on the ship, and to load onto the ship a pair of each animals, one male and one female.

In this manner a small group of about forty people boarded the ship, the sum total of those who believed in Nabi Nooh عليه السلام.

Then the order was given for the heavens to open up and rain started falling and the fountains of the earth were ordered to open up and gush forth. With the grace of Allah

the ship started sailing until such time that all the rejecters of truth were drowned as a result of their evil deeds.

Mount Judy

When the punishment of Allah had been completed, the ship came to a standstill on Mount Judy.

"And the matter was ended the Ark rested on Mount Judy and the word went forth: "Away with those who do wrong." (11:44)

The water started receding and drying up. The inhabitants of the ship once again put their feet ashore in safety. For this reason Nabi Nooh  is also known as the "second father of mankind" or "the second Adam." And it is perhaps also because of this that in *Hadith* he is mentioned as being the "first of the Messengers (*Rasuls*)."¹

As for the where about of Mount Judy, the Qur'ān only mentions the place where the ship came to a standstill. However according to some commentators on the *Towraat* Judy is the name of a mountain range which is found in Ararat and the mountainous region of Georgia.

Important Conclusions

1. Every person is answerable for his every action. For this reason the righteousness of a father cannot be held responsible for the disobedience of a son and neither can the holiness of a son be a compensation for the evils of a father.

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1. The person on whom Allah's revelation comes is called a '*Nabi*' and the one who receives a new *Shariat* is called a '*Rasul*' (Messenger). Every *Rasul* is also a *Nabi* but it is not necessary that every *Nabi* will be a *Rasul*.

"Everyone acts according to his own disposition."

(17:84)

2. The company of evil ones is more dangerous than poison. And its result is nothing other than disgrace, loss and destruction. Just as righteousness is necessary for a person, so important is the company of the righteous. And just as it is necessary to avoid all evil, so also is it necessary to save yourself from the company of the bad ones.

3. It is not contrary to the rules of *Tawakkul* that a person should make provision for eventualities, but in fact it is the correct way to rely on Allah. For this reason the ship was built as a provision.

For Man it is necessary at first to make effort

And then if he wishes he may make *Du'a*.

As long as no effort was made by hand and might

Nooh  would not have found safely from the flood.

4. The Messengers of Allah although being *Ma'sum* (sinless) and innocent, they are still through their humanity capable of human faults. However, they do not continue on it but from Allah's side they are quickly made aware thereof and made to stop. Further, those Messengers are not knowers of the unseen as can clearly be seen from the story of Nabi Nooh .

5. Although the law of retribution for deeds committed is a law that is prevalent in every corner of the universe, it is not necessary that every crime or every deed of righteousness should be rewarded or punished this world. This is so because this world has been established as a world for deeds whereas the hereafter has been especially fixed for the reward and punishment. However, the punishment

for injustice and arrogance is given in some form or other in this world also.

Saying:

It is reported that Imam Abu Hanifah said that the unjust one and the proud arrogant one will meet his punishment in some form or other in this world before his death. Hence the stories of the people who opposed Allah's Messengers (*Alaihimus Salām*) and the greatly unjust ones in history are eloquent proof of this.

The Deluge of Nabi Nooh ﷺ

The historians have mentioned the name of Nabi Nooh (*Alaihis Salām*)'s son as being Kan'aan. This is in accordance with the *Towraat*. The Qur'ān, however, is silent on this issue. But being silent on the name does not detract from the importance of the story. The conversation between Nabi Nooh ﷺ and his son is mentioned:

The son said (in reply to his father's offer to believe and board the ship):

"I shall seek refuge on a mountain which will save me from the water."

(Hood:43)

Some *Ulama* are of the opinion that this was not a true son of Nabi Nooh ﷺ and they then made two further claims: (a) Some say he was the son of Nooh (*Alaihis Salām*)'s wife from a previous marriage who was reared by him (b) Some claim that the non-believing wife of Nabi Nooh ﷺ had deceived him and he was born.

The reason why these *Ulama* had resorted to these, unsubstantiated interpretations is the fact how can it be that the son of Nabi can be non-believer? What should be

remembered is that to bring the message of guidance to mankind. He is not required to use force to cause his children, his wife, family-members or members of his tribe to believe and submit to the message.

The Qur'ān says to Rasulullah ﷺ:

"You have not been a forceful ruler over them
(the unbelievers)." (88:22)

"You are not one to overance them by force.
(50:45)

The truth of the matter is that Kan'aan was the son of Nabi Nooh عليه السلام but due to his unbelieving mother who reared him and the effect of the family and the general environment there was a bad influence on him and he remained a non-believer in spite of being the son of messenger of Allah.

The Flood was it Universal or Local?

Did this flood come over the whole earth or was it merely a specific region that was flooded? Among the ancient *Ulama* as well as the modern *Ulama* there have always been two opinions on this issue. This is also the case with the *Ulama* of the Jews and the Christians.

According to some experts in astronomy and geologists the flood was only limited to that area where the people of Nabi Nooh عليه السلام resided. This region consists of an area 140.000 square kilometre.

However, the correct version is this that the deluge was confined to a specific area and was not universal. The Qur'ān only focussed on those details which were of importance as admonition or warning. It only wishes to point out to men of understanding that this incident in

history should be noted and never forgotten, that so many years ago a specific nation persisted with disobedience to Allah and rejected the guidance brought by Allah's chosen Messenger who was sent to them and in response Allah showed His power and caused the disobedient ones to be drowned while only a small group of believers were saved, with Nabi Nooh ؑ.

"Verily in that there is a warning for men of understanding."

The Age of Nabi Nooh ؑ

The Qur'ān clearly states that Nabi Nooh ؑ continuous to preach to his people for nine hundred and fifty years.

"We sent Nooh ؑ to his people and he turned among them a thousand years excepts fifty."

(29:14)

This life span of 950 years from a natural point of view seems quite illogical. It is however not impossible because at the beginning of this Universe there was not such an abundance of sorrows and worries or illnesses as we have today. Furthermore ancient history also admits that a few thousand years ago the natural life-span of man was much more than now. Hazrat Nooh (*Alaihis Salām*)'s life-span of so many years should be understand to be one of those special gifts from Allah's side towards His messengers. In this regard the correct version is that was his life-span and there is no need to try to shorten his life by various interpretations.

In the Qur'ān Nabi Nooh ؑ is mentioned in 28 chapters and he is mentioned 43 times. "

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

(Stories of the Prophets)

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Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

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P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
Strand, South Africa